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ED305 Assignment 2: Using Psychology and Sociology of Education to Make Sense of My School Experience

For this assignment, I have chosen the two experiences that stood out to me as the most important throughout my time on teaching practice in terms of developing my identity as a pre-service teacher. In issue one I will explore how my sense of self-concept and self-efficacy have influenced my view of inclusive education. In issue two, I will try to understand better how the idea of meritocracy effected the school experience of a working-class student.

These issues took place during this year's teaching practice that I undertook in an urban DEIS school that facilitates 300 students. These students are of diverse cultural backgrounds, and predominantly low socio-economic backgrounds. My placement in the school involved: teaching a mainstream mixed-level Transition Year maths class, observing and team-teaching a First Year ordinary level maths class, resource hours with a Leaving Cert maths student during school, resource hours as part of the After School Study programme provided to the students for free by the school.

Issue One: Identity

This 2019/2020 academic year marked my return to college, after multiple failed attempts at progression. During those previous failed attempts, I was diagnosed with a mental health condition, and this greatly affected my beliefs about myself as a student as well as a student-teacher. Before this teaching practice began, I already felt anxious and defeated. These emotions were prominent throughout the beginning of my teaching practice. As my teaching practice continued, however, my emotions and outlook improved greatly, and this was reflected in my teaching and then in the behaviour and learning of the students I had the pleasure of teaching.

I chose this experience as I feel it's important to better understand the relationship between my identity as a teacher and my performance in class. A deeper understanding of how mental disability, academic performance and teaching interact will also help me make informed decisions in terms of inclusive education. It has been identified that in an inclusive education system, "every child and young person deserves an equal chance to access, participate in and benefit from education" and "each person should have the opportunity to reach her/his full educational potential" (DES, 2005, p.7). Students with special educational needs should be educated alongside their peers in mainstream classes as much as possible (EPSEN Act, 2004), and an important factor in the success of inclusive education is how teachers themselves perceive disability and special educational needs (Butler & Shelvin, 2001). Based on this, I will investigate my own experience with disability and how it has influenced my approach to inclusive teaching.

When I first began this BME I was relatively confident, based on prior experience, in my academic and teaching potential. Over time, however, due to experiencing traumatic events and a resulting diagnosis of Complex Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder, my identity as a growing teacher and as a hard-working student seemed to disappear. Students experiencing post-traumatic stress have been shown to be at an increased risk of school burnout and developing depressive symptoms (Lucier-Greer et al., 2019). Learning this has helped me make sense of how the excitement and pride I normally felt while teaching was replaced by feelings of inability and emotional exhaustion. My teaching performance began to reflect my negative emotions, with a negative classroom atmosphere characterised by student frustration and behavioural and motivational issues. These issues and my teaching performance all improved significantly by the time my teaching practice ended. I believe this was due to changes in my self-concept.

Self-concept has been identified as an important factor in teacher development, having been shown to influence approaches to teaching, beliefs about students and risk of teacher burnout (Guskey, 1988; Friedman & Farber, 1992; Woolfolk et al., 2013). Described as "a multidimensional structure of identity which includes self-esteem, group identity, and self-efficacy" (Bogart, 2014, p. 108), self-concept is also something that can be strongly affected by the acquisition of a disability. Research has shown that acquiring a disability "often appears to be a stunning blow to one's identity" (Smart, 2019, p.361). Being able to make sense of identity and self-concept is very important to me, not only as a pre-service teacher

developing their identity but also for teaching students that are going through adolescence or are members of minority groups, like those with disabilities.

Social Identity Theory asserts that individuals strive for positive self-concept, by identifying and relating to positive aspects of social groups they feel a part of (Tajfel & Turner, 1979). People who are members of stigmatized groups are at risk of negative self-concept, as they take part in a society where the dominant group may view the stigmatized group in a negative light (Crocker & Major, 1989). To improve their self-concept and manage stigma, members of stigmatized groups may attempt to assimilate, distancing themselves from their minority group and ultimately taking on the majority group's values and negative view of the minority group they belong to (Tajfel and Turner, 1979; Dunn & Burcaw, 2013). This insight has helped me recognise that my teaching was striving to be as 'normal' as possible, after developing strong feelings of shame about being a teacher with a disability. This kind of reaction to a disability is more common in those with "invisible disabilities such as learning disabilities or mental illness" (Bogart, 2014, p.113), who are less likely to find comfort in similar others due to their stigma being concealable (Fribley et al., 1998). Alternatively, people with disabilities may begin to develop a sense of disability pride by identifying as part of their minority group and reinterpreting the stigmatization in a positive light (Dunn and Burcaw, 2013). This results in a more positive self-concept, and it is thankfully something that I have identified as happening by the end of my teaching placement as a result of increasing self-efficacy.

Bandura (1997, p.3) defines self-efficacy as "beliefs in one's capabilities to organise and execute the courses of action required to produce given attainments". My teacher self-efficacy, for example, can be described as my beliefs about my own capacity "to bring about desired outcomes of student engagement and learning, even among students who may be difficult or unmotivated" (Tschannen-Moran & Hoy, 2001, p.783). Evidence suggests that significant changes to self-concept and self-efficacy in one context can generalize to other situations (McConnell, 2011; Bandura, 1977). Furthermore, it has been shown that teachers require a clear sense of self in order to respect and bring about cultural or academic change in their students (Warin et al., 2006). For these reasons, I believe that my academic, teaching and disability self-concepts are closely related and strongly dependent on my sense of self-efficacy. I hope to better understand how changes in my self-efficacy throughout teaching practice have made these self-concepts and my teaching more positive. Bandura (1977, p.195) advises "expectations of personal efficacy are based on four major sources of information": physiological states, vicarious experience, verbal persuasion, and performance accomplishments.

Beginning with physiological states, I can now identify an important interaction I had with my co-operating teacher on my first day of teaching the Transition Year class. Frozen with anxiety in the days prior, my sense of self-efficacy was extremely low. The morning of the class I asked the teacher could I observe the teacher instead of teaching, due to strong feelings of anxiety and not feeling capable of doing it. The teacher kindly refused and advised the only way to improve that was to teach through it. My teaching in the following few weeks was hindered by this physiological state, I dismissed modern teaching methods as being out

of my ability and was pre-occupied with what could go wrong in the class, managing behaviour through traditional teaching methods. A notable memory I have with them was after a long class of controlling classroom behaviour, one student commented “looks like you’re having a bad day today, sir”. This prompted a strong realisation that my emotions were not only affecting my teaching style but could also be perceived by the students and influence their behaviour. I was reminded that they were human too and, like me, would benefit from a positive atmosphere. I began to try making the classes as relatable and enjoyable as possible for the students. Over time my own anxiety, fear and negativity diminished, and self-efficacy improved. By bringing a more relaxed and positive mindset to the class the students began to engage more and felt more relaxed and positive towards the maths too.

In terms of vicarious experiences, my co-operating teacher was happy to let me observe her other classes. I took the opportunity to observe as many classes as I could and was surprised that she also had difficulty with some students’ behaviour. This helped me identify an aspect of my own teaching I had been struggling with. Occasionally I would be completely ignored by certain students. Situations like that would leave me feeling very self-conscious about my teaching ability. I had begun to conclude that I just wasn’t good enough to teach anymore. Through observing my co-operating teacher, I could see that she was ignored too, and had to deal with far wilder classroom behaviour than I had. A key difference that I observed was that she kept persisting and wasn’t embarrassed or afraid to repeatedly pursue the outcomes that she wanted from the students. I began to do the same in my class to great results, students that had previously ignored me now began to focus on the maths and engaged in the classroom activities. This experience sparked a change in my self-efficacy in terms of how I felt my disability effected my potential growth. I had previously seen difficulties in the classroom as being a fixed result of my disability, rather than in the context of me being a pre-service teacher. After observing, relating to, and learning from a more experienced teacher I now felt hopeful that I still had the capacity to grow as both a teacher and person.

Verbal persuasion is something that stands out in improving my sense of self-efficacy. Closer to the beginning of the year, a negative academic self-concept was strongly influencing my self-efficacy as a teacher. If I was someone struggling to complete assignments, who was I to ask students to challenge themselves academically? An interaction with a lecturer left a lasting impression, where I spoke to them about my mental health condition. I was surprised that they saw me as a hard worker despite previous failings, and that they suggested my experience would better prepare me to teach disadvantaged students. This description of myself didn’t fit with my negative self-concept so was initially dismissed, but I tried to consider the possibility that it was true. Following this interaction, I had an experience with a First-Year student who emphatically stated, “I can’t do that sir, I can’t read!”. My initial reaction was a feeling of low self-efficacy, waiting for the Special Needs Assistant to help, as I felt unprepared and unsure if I knew how best to help the student. Remembering my lecturer’s comments, however, I noticed how strongly I related to how this student was feeling. I felt motivated to help them through the challenge of reading the maths question in a way that I would want to be if I was struggling with it: by explaining that I can find reading hard sometimes too, leading by example, keeping a positive attitude, and praising them when

they progressed through it. The student grew enthusiastic after getting the maths questions right after successfully reading it, and we continued through the rest of them together. At the end of the class the SNA commented that she saw I was doing good work with the student. This comment cemented the increased self-efficacy that I felt after putting my lecturer's advice into action.

Lastly, I've been able to identify how performance accomplishments have informed my sense of self-efficacy also. As my teaching practice progressed, and as the other examples above improved my sense of self-efficacy, I began to gain confidence in planning my lessons away from traditionalist values and more towards those of social constructivism inclusion. I found it challenging to carry out lessons designed around: activities and group selection scaffolded to maximise the learning of all students, relatable examples that promote student discussion and their natural curiosity for learning. My sense of self-efficacy improved weekly based on positive experiences with the class and seeing their learning improve. These efforts culminated in a teaching inspection that praised me for my lesson preparation, teaching style and my rapport with the students, which is very much in contrast with what I felt was possible at the beginning of the teaching placement.

Sociologically, I have shown how social identity has had an impact on my understanding of minority groups and my ability to carry out an inclusive teaching philosophy. By applying the psychology of education, I have identified examples of how improvements in self-efficacy have brought about positive changes in my academic, teaching and disability self-concepts. Feelings of inability and defeat have transformed into a sense of pride and excitement for my future as a teacher with a disability. I have gained important insight into how self-efficacy and self-concept can affect academic performance as well as how they can be improved, and hope to use this insight in future to create learning environments that promote self-efficacy and to help maximise my students' achievement.

Issue Two: Meritocracy

During my teaching practice I was assigned a resource class with a working-class Leaving Cert student, described to me as a “weak” and a “problem student”. I was advised that I shouldn’t expect them to show up for the class. After two weeks, I found the student and convinced them to attend the resource class. Apprehensive at first, he spoke to me about his dislike for mathematics and teachers in general, and that he wasn’t sure if he was going to sit the Leaving Cert at all. He struggled with any topic I’d begin to teach, but after focusing on more foundational mathematical concepts the student started growing confident and started doing much better with Leaving Certificate questions. The student spoke to me about how he liked coming to my class because I treated him differently than other teachers and didn’t “give out to him” for his behaviour. The student showed a new willingness to learn and asked for extra help after school as he couldn’t afford private tutoring. I helped him as much as I could, and throughout the year his performance, behaviour and outlook on education improved greatly.

I chose this experience because it made me feel conflicted about my position in the education system. I felt morally obliged to seek out this student and try to help them as much as I could, but as I was doing so, part of me wondered if it was due to some pre-service teacher naivety. If I was a full-time teacher would this extra help be fair to other students? Would I eventually start seeing certain students as “weak” and lower my expectations? I hope to make more sense of this experience through research into the idea of meritocracy.

Meritocracy has been described as a society where the talents, attitude, and hard work of an individual is what determines their success or failure in society (Considine and Dukelow, 2009). Originally coined in a satirical work by Michael Young (1958), there is widespread allegiance to a meritocratic viewpoint in Ireland (Kennedy and Power, 2010). With merit being so concisely defined as “Intelligence + Effort = Merit” (Young, 1958, p.94), I feel like a deeper understanding of intelligence and effort in the case of this student will help me make sense of this experience.

The first psychologist to investigate intelligence scientifically believed that there were two factors involved in cognitive performance, a general intelligence factor and situation specific factors (Spearman, 1904). For example, remembering a set of numbers would involve the general *g* factor as well as the specific *s* factor related to recall something from memory. This *g* factor affects performance on all intellectual tasks, and Spearman suggested that “*g* alone is of psychological significance (Roberts & Lipnevich, 2012, p.9). The concept of general intelligence has gone on to inform many other theories of intelligence (Cattell, 1963; Carroll, 1993). Cattell (1963), for example, divides general intelligence into fluid and crystallized intelligence. Fluid intelligence is a relatively fixed aspect of intelligence that is tied to brain development and relates to an individual’s “mental efficiency [and] non-verbal abilities” (Woolfolk et al., 2013, p.128). Crystallised intelligence includes skills learned throughout life and is developed “by investing fluid intelligence in solving problems” (Woolfolk et al., 2013, p.129). The most widely accepted theory combines the work of Cattell with other psychologists, ‘Cattell-Horn-Carroll’ theory proposes a hierarchical three-level model of intelligence (Sternberg, 2012). General intelligence, at the top level, informs a second level of

8 broad abilities including fluid and crystallised intelligence, and visual-spatial reasoning. These broad abilities connect to over 80 narrow abilities at the third level, like writing ability and listening ability. Dismissing the importance of a general *g* factor, a contrasting view on intelligence is Gardner's (1983) theory of multiple intelligences which views intelligence as 8 distinct abilities, including logical-mathematical, interpersonal and intrapersonal intelligences. Although lacking in scientific evidence, the multiple intelligences view is popular with teachers worldwide (Waterhouse, 2006; Jonsson et al., 2012).

Knowledge of scientific theories of intelligence can be beneficial to educators as they can help us plan lessons in a way that enhance student learning (Lynch & Warner, 2012), and teacher's opinion on intelligence has been shown to have a large impact on student achievement (Jonsson et al., 2012; Dweck, 1999; Carr & Dweck, 2011). This experience initially stood out to me as I felt very uncomfortable when the student was so matter-of-factly described as "weak". This isn't the first time I've encountered this kind of language in school, and I found it disempowering to me as a teacher and insulting to the student. Any time that I have heard descriptions like "weak" it has never inspired hope that I can make a difference as a teacher. The idea that intelligence is fixed and unchangeable, described as entity theory (Dweck 1999), has been shown to decrease motivation, learning and achievement in students (Dweck, 1999; Carr & Dweck, 2011) and is more common in mathematics than other subjects (Rattan et al., 2012). In contrast, teacher's holding an incremental view where intelligence is believed to be changeable over time has been shown to improve those outcomes. The views held by teachers are so influential that students are seen to take them on board themselves, for better or for worse (Rosenthal & Jacobsen, 1992). This knowledge of scientific and implicit theories of intelligence and their potential effects has helped me no longer feel naive or out of place as a pre-service teacher for having my own opinion and practices. With this understanding, I can see now that an important factor in the student's improvement in maths was my own incremental view of intelligence and my attempt to approach his learning from a new angle. I chose to use an iPad game called "Dragonbox: Algebra 12+", which is a very interactive and vibrant game based around the rules of algebra. I was trying to promote learning in a student who was struggling with traditional pen and paper methods, making sure to let him know that I thought he was "very capable", and it was a great success. The student was excited to play the game, and even more excited when we later practiced Leaving Certificate algebra questions and he saw the connections to the rules of the game he was playing. He discussed with me how he didn't initially believe me when I said he could do it, but now was surprised at his progress.

Gardner (1995, p.208), has commented previously that a core aspect of multiple intelligence theory is wanting to take "human differences seriously". Combining this view with an incremental view of intelligence, this experience has shown me the importance of trying to promote learning in all students, by adapting my own teaching rather than writing them off as weak and expecting them to adapt for me. In terms of the meritocratic view, the fact that student achievement can be so dependent on the teacher's own opinions and expectations of them highlights problems of equality in a meritocratic system.

In their investigation of social class barriers in education, Lynch & O’Riordan (1998, p. 445) identify structuralist functionalism as one of the most enduring theoretical frameworks which can be used to explain inequalities in the education system. Functionalist sociology describes a functioning society as consisting of interdependent systems that each contribute to the stability of society, based on a consensus of shared values (Sadovnik, 2011). Durkheim (1956, p.28) viewed education as “the influence exercised by adult generations on those that are not yet ready for social life”, socialising students based on the values deemed appropriate by society, and sorting and selecting students based on their abilities. Schools are seen to have different functions that work toward the consensus of a functionalist society: intellectual, political, social and economic (Bennett & LeCompte, 1990).

These different functions have helped me make sense of my interaction with the student. When I first met him, he brought attention to how he avoided participating in maths class because of clashing with his teacher. An example of the social function of education, his teacher had issues with how they spoke and the kind of questions they were asking. After being chastised for his behaviour the student disengaged from learning maths entirely, falling behind his peers with regards to the intellectual function of mathematical understanding. His disengagement, in my opinion, is an example of conflict between functions of the functionalist framework rather than a lack of effort on his part. On the one hand, intellectual functions of education involve students developing an inquisitive mindset to explore, understand and experiment within specific topics chosen by a teacher. Yet social functions require “obedience to authority and ‘correct’ behaviour” sometimes without question (Bartlett and Burton, 2016, p.17). Both functionalists and Marxists acknowledge the effect of a hidden curriculum, where social inequalities are reproduced due to students receiving differing educations based on social class norms (Lynch, 1989). Functionalists have described economic and social inequality as an inevitable and necessary function of society, to ensure that the most important positions in society will be filled by the most talented people based on shared values (Davis and Moore, 1945). In contrast to this view, conflict theorists like Marxists identify that education promotes the dominant ideologies of the higher class and its structure reproduces the class system through its conflict with the working class (Sadovnik, 2011). This student’s situation is an example, to me, of inequality in the education system that shows how different emphasis can be put on the different functions of education depending on a teacher’s impression of the student. Some students might be given more freedom to express themselves while others have an educational experience like this student, more focused on modifying their behaviour.

In my opinion, the student’s teacher had a very meritocratic view of the education system and of the student themselves. My experience with the student was very different than what I expected based on their teacher’s description of a “weak”, “problem student”. After finally meeting the student and building a rapport with them, I found that I could relate to the student’s point of view and saw more fault in the different functions of the education system than in him personally. While his behaviour was sometimes ‘incorrect’ and off-topic (e.g. calling school ‘rubbish’, asking for my first name) I found this a great opportunity to connect with him. After time spent in a positive one-on-one environment, the student felt more comfortable and not only applied themselves more to challenging maths questions but also

challenged their own apprehension of sitting the Leaving Cert. Instead of the term “weak”, my new understanding of intelligence and social class would rather describe students like him as struggling. In my opinion, the student’s difficulties were a result of his place within a contradictory meritocratic system that puts blame on the student rather than itself as a broken system. The fact that he began to overcome these difficulties through extra one-on-one tutoring that he normally wouldn’t be able to afford shows again that social class can have an unfair impact on achievement. Highlighting examples like private education and extra-curricular activities, Lynch and Cream (2018) explain that Irish children from poorer households cannot engage with the education system on equal terms with others as they do not have equal resources in a time of rising economic inequality. They describe the idea of meritocracy as “an unrealizable myth in an economically unequal society”.

Burns (2014, p.9) has advised that implicit cultural assumptions held by teachers in DEIS schools, like the validity of a meritocratic system or the validity of fixed ability, results in “normalisation of low student attainment” and a “self-imposed achievement ceiling in relation to what they as educators can achieve”. By challenging those assumptions in this issue, I feel this experience has emphasised to me the importance of my own values and efforts as a teacher toward maximising every student’s achievement as much as I can.

Conclusion

Research into the effectiveness of teacher education programmes has commented on “the lack of impact teacher education has on students’ beliefs about teaching and learning and their later practices in schools” (Klein, 1998, p.1). Many Irish teachers feel that “research is of little practical value to them” (Gleeson, 2012, p.1), and that most of their skills “were acquired in classroom and school settings rather than during initial teacher education” (Gleeson, 2012, p.12). After carrying out this assignment, my own opinion is that educational theory and reflection can be combined in a way that leads to powerful conclusions that can have long-term effects on my teaching. Making sense of issues involving identity, inclusive teaching, meritocracy and social class has motivated and excited me about the possibilities of teaching and I endeavour to keep up with research as I continue in my practice.

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